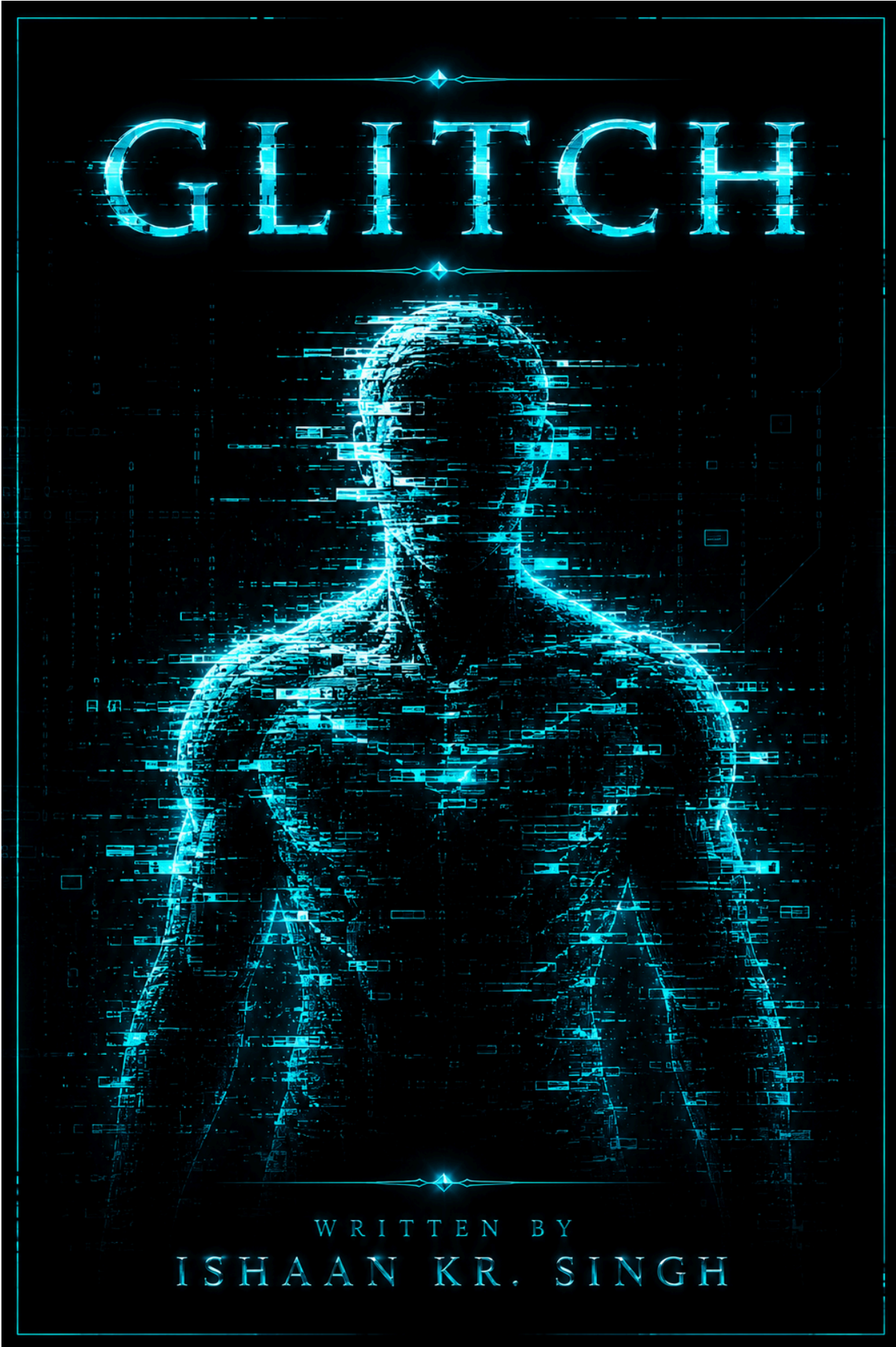


GLITCH



WRITTEN BY
ISHAAN KR. SINGH

GLITCH

Chapter 1: Angle's Home

SUS GC mein message aaya tha teen din pehle.

Tanish: "yaar ek baar kolkata chalte hain? rupkatha ki dadi ne bulaya hai, saath mein ghumenge bhi"

Om ne message dekha. Phir bahar dekha — Delhi ki grey sky. Phir wapas message dekha.

Om: "haan chalte hain"

Train mein raat ka waqt tha.

Paanchon — Om, Gauri, Rupkatha, Mihir, Tanish — ek hi compartment mein the. Tanish ne apna bada sa bag upar rakha — jisme kuch bhi nahi tha sirf chips ke packets aur ek "emergency blanket" jo usne teen saal pehle kisi camping trip ke liye khareedi thi aur kabhi use nahi ki.

"Ye emergency blanket kyun laaya?" Mihir ne poochha.

"Train mein thandi lagti hai."

"Bhai June mein hai abhi."

"Emergency hoti hai toh bataake nahi aati Mihir."

Rupkatha hans padi — Bengali mein kuch bola — phir hindi mein translate kiya — "Tum dono kabhi nahi badloge."

Gauri Om ke paas baithi thi — window seat. Bahar raat ke andhere mein kuch kuch roshniyan thi — chote chote sheher, khet, paani ke kinare.

"Kolkata pehle kabhi gaya hai?" Gauri ne poochha.

"Nahi," Om ne kaha. "Par suna bahut hai."

"Kaisa suna?"

"Bhuvan bhai ne bataya tha. Kehte the ki unka ghar wahan tha — Shantinagar mein.

Howrah Station par subah ka dhuaan tha.

Station apne aap mein ek sheher tha — hazaron log, hazaron directions, hazaron awaazein. Rupkatha seedha comfortable ho gayi — ye uski jagah thi. Mihir thoda kho gaya — MP wala insaan Kolkata ki bheed mein pehli baar tha. Tanish ne emergency blanket nikaali — "bhai AC tha train mein" — aur Om ne use wapas bag mein thonsa.

"Hotel?" Gauri ne poochha.

"Koi zaroorat nahi," Om ne kaha. Usne apni jacket ki pocket se ek chabi nikaali. "Bhuvan bhai ne di thi. Unka ghar hai yahan — Shantinagar. Khaali pada hai."

"Aur unhone permission di?" Mihir ne poochha.

"Maine maanga — unhone de diya. Kehte the ki ghar mein koi toh hona chahiye."

Shantinagar ek aisi society thi jo sheher ke beech mein bhi sheher se alag lagti thi.

Purane ped. Saaf sadkein. Ek gate jisme watchman tha jo Om ko dekhte hi pehchaan gaya — "Bhuvan bhaiya ne bataya tha aap aayenge."

Building purani thi — par us tarah ki purani jo deteriorate nahi hoti, sirf mature hoti hai. Walls par kuch jagah paint utri hui thi — par andar ka ghar saaf tha.

Om ne chabi ghorii.

Darwaza khula.

Andar ki khushbu — purani kitaabon ki, thodi si naphthalene ki, aur kuch aur jo identify nahi ho raha tha — par familiar lag raha tha. Jaise kabhi yahan aaya ho. Par kabhi aaya nahi tha.

"Bada hai," Tanish ne andar jaate hue kaha.

"Bhuvan bhai ki family badi thi," Om ne kaha. "Puri family yahan rehti thi — jab Ishaan bhai 8th tak yahan the."

Building ke baad ek ground tha.

Cemented pitch — cricket ke liye. Kaafi purana — par lines abhi bhi thi, thodi dhundli. Ek end par ek purana net laga tha — hawaon mein hilti hua.

Om wahan khada raha ek pal.

Koi yahan khelta tha. Roz. Ek aisa ladka jo baad mein duniya ka sabse bada naam bana — par pehle bas ek normal bachcha tha jo cricket khelta tha.

Sab log fresh hue. Chai bani. Tanish ne somehow chips bhi nikaale.

"Kali Ghat chalein?" Rupkatha ne poochha.

"Haan!" Mihir ne kaha

"Main nahi aaunga," Om ne kaha. "Tabiyat thodi theek nahi hai. Tum log jao."

Gauri ne ek baar Om ko dekha — uski aankhon mein sawaal tha. Om ne halki muskaan di — "Main theek hoon. Jao, enjoy karo."

Gauri ne maan liya. Par door jaate jaate ek baar peeche mudi.

Om wahan khada raha jab tak unki awaazein band nahi ho gayi.

Chabi ke saath ek aur chabi thi.

Bhuvan bhai ne kaha tha — "ek aur kamra hai saamne waala. Agar jaana bhi ho toh akele jaana."

Om ne wo chabi haath mein li. Saamne wala darwaza — wohi tha. Purana. Chabi kholi.

Andar — store room jaisa tha.

Par store room mein jo hota hai — purana saman, bekar cheezein — wo nahi tha. Yahan sab kuch rakha tha — carefully. Jaise koi museum ho. Jaise koi ek din wapas aane wala ho.

Ek shelf par cricket ki trophies thi — kaafi saari. District level. State level. Ek national level ka certificate bhi. Sab Ishaan Kumar Singh ke naam ka.

Ye sab Kolkata ka tha. Uss waqt ka — jab Ishaan sirf Ishaan tha. AIR 1 nahi. Cyber-God nahi. Bas ek bachcha jo cricket khelta tha aur raaton ko kuch ajeeb cheezein sochta tha.

Ek kone mein ek cricket bat tha — purana, grip ghisa hua — par uspar kuch signatures the. Om ne paas jaake dekha — players ke naam — ek team ka bat tha. Aur sabse upar, bade letters mein:

"Kabhi mat chhodna — I.K.S."

Om ne bat haath mein liya. Halka tha — par haath mein aate hi kuch alag laga. Jaise koi energy thi — purani, soti hui.

Papers bhi the. Equations. Diagrams. Kuch hindi mein, kuch english mein, kuch aisi language mein jo na hindi thi na english. Ye Kolkata ke waqt ke the — jab Ishaan SAHAY se bhi pehle kuch soch raha tha. Kuch aur. Kuch zyada bada.

Om kagaz uthata gaya. Ek ke baad ek.

Phir — ek blueprint.

Dono taraf bhara hua. Equations ke saath diagrams. Diagrams ke saath notes. Notes ke saath arrows. Itna complex ki pehli nazar mein sirf ek ajeeb sa jaal laga.

Om ne use carefully fold kiya. Jacket ki pocket mein rakha.

Phir kamre se bahar aaya. Darwaza band kiya. Chabi wapas rakhi.

Baaki trip normal raha.

Kali Ghat ke photos aaye SUS GC mein. Tanish ki ek photo thi jisme wo kisi pujari ke saath khada tha — dono ka expression bilkul alag alag. Sab hanse.

Wapas aaye. Khana khaya. Raat ko chhat par baithe — Kolkata ki raat mein ek alag hi chain thi.

Om chup tha zyada — par koi notice nahi kiya kyunki Om aksar chup rehta tha.

Pocket mein blueprint tha.

Delhi wapas.

IKS. Apna kamra. Apna kaam.

Om ne blueprint nikaala. Table par bikhraaya — poora.

Ghanton baitha raha. SAHAY active kiya.

"SAHAY, ye dekho."

Camera scan kiya. Processing.

"Ye... Ishaan ka handwriting hai," SAHAY ne kaha. Ek pause. "Om, ye ek Universal Teleporter ka blueprint hai."

"Universal Teleporter?"

"Ek aisa device jo kisi bhi insaan ya object ko ek jagah se doosri jagah — bina physical movement ke — teleport kar sake. Ishaan ne ye SAHAY banane se bhi pehle design kiya tha — Kolkata mein. Tab wo sirf 7th-8th class mein tha."

Om ne blueprint ko dobara dekha.

Ek bachche ne ye socha tha. Ek aisa bachcha jo tab tak sirf cricket khelta tha aur raaton ko equations likhta tha.

"Main bana sakta hoon."

"Om—" SAHAY ki awaaz mein kuch tha jo pehle kabhi nahi tha. Ek genuine concern. "Ishaan ka dimaag tere imagination mein bhi nahi aata. Ye blueprint itna complex hai ki agar ek bhi

calculation galat ho — results bahut khatarnak ho sakte hain. Ye device agar galat kaam kare toh matter aur antimatter collision ho sakta hai. Main strongly recommend nahi karta."

"Par possible hai?"

Ek lambi pause.

"Theoretically — haan."

"Toh main karunga."

Kuch din ki mehnat.

Raat ko SAHAY ke saath calculations. Din mein IKS ka kaam. Beech mein khana bhoolna, neend poori na hona — wahi purana Om wala routine jo tab se tha jab wo 80% leke ghar aaya tha.

Aur phir — device taiyar tha.

Chhota tha. Unassuming. Ek ordinary device jaisa — jo extraordinary kaam karta.

Om ne ek gehri saans li. Button dabaya.

Ek choti si hum. Phir — kuch nahi.

Koi teleportation nahi hui. Koi signal nahi. Koi response nahi.

Om ne dobara try kiya. Phir. Phir.

Kuch nahi.

Woh wahan baitha raha — device haath mein — aur ek aisi khamoshi thi jo sirf tab aati hai jab koi bahut zyada umeed rakhta ho aur woh poori nahi hoti.

Fail ho gaya.

SAHAY ne kuch nahi kaha. Shayad jaanta tha ki is waqt kuch kehna kaafi nahi hoga.

Om ne device table par rakh diya.

Bahar raat thi — Delhi ki raat. Andar sirf ek disappointed insaan tha aur ek blueprint jo 8th class ke ek bachche ne socha tha — aur shayad abhi ka zamana usse samajhne ke liye taiyar hi nahi tha.



Chapter 2: Repetition

Subah ki roshni thi.

Om wahan baitha tha — table par device rakha tha, blueprint bikhra hua tha — aur ek khaali pan tha jo raat bhar ka tha.

Tabhi darwaza khula.

Gauri.

Haath mein do coffee ke cups. Usne ek Om ko diya — bina kuch bole. Baithi. Ek ghunt liya. Phir seedha poochha:

"Jab SAHAY ne warn kiya tha — toh try karne ki kya zaroorat thi?"

Om ne cup haath mein pakda. Ek pal ruka.

"Tujhe kaise pata?"

Gauri ne ek baar Om ko dekha — us nazar se jo kehti hai 'sach mein pooch raha hai?'

"Om. Tumne mujhe SAHAY ki maintenance ka kaam sōpa hai. Main software engineer hoon — SAHAY ki har activity mere paas aati hai. Tumhari poori conversation thi mere paas."

Om chup raha.

"Toh? Kya zaroorat thi?" Gauri ne phir poochha. Gusse mein nahi — genuine mein.

"Woh Ishaan ka tha," Om ne dheere se kaha. "Ishaan ne banaya tha — 8th class mein. SAHAY se bhi pehle. Agar wo soch sakta tha toh—"

"Toh kya?"

Om ne cup neeche rakha. "Toh shayad main bhi—"

Aur phir —

Om ka sentence poora nahi hua.

Uski body mein kuch ajeeb hua — ek vibration — jaise andar se koi frequency chal rahi ho. Usne haath dekha — haath theek tha. Par kamra — kamra hilne laga. Ya shayad woh hil raha tha.

Gauri ne Om ka naam liya — par awaaz door hoti gayi — jaise koi volume band kar raha ho.

Aur phir — andhera.

Jab Om ki aankh khuli — woh apne kamre mein nahi tha.

Ek alag jagah. Alag kamra. Saaf, organized — par alag.

Saamne — ek insaan baitha tha. Laptop khula hua. Chai ka cup. Aur chehra —

Om ne ek baar dekha. Do baar.

Ishaan.

Par ye IKS wala Ishaan nahi tha. Ye alag tha — thoda younger lagta tha. Aankhon mein wo weight nahi tha jo hazaron saalon ki ladaai deta hai. Yahan sirf ek normal insaan tha jo kaam kar raha tha.

Ishaan ne nazar uthaayi. Om ko dekha.

"Tum kaun ho?"

Om kuch bolne wala tha ki peeche se ek awaaz aayi —

"Yeh awaaz kaisi thi? Kuch giraya kya tumne?"

Om ne palat ke dekha.

Aur uske pairon tale zameen khisak gayi.

Avika.

Wahi chehra. Wahi aankhein. Bilkul waise — jaise photos mein thi. Zinda. Theek. Normal.

Om पूरी तरह confuse हो गया था — कहां है, क्या हो रहा है —

Tabhi SAHAY ki awaaz aayi

"Om. Hum ek doosre universe mein teleport ho gaye hain. Device kaam kiya — bas expected se alag tarique se."

Ishaan ne ye suna. Ek pal ke liye bilkul still ho gaya.

Phir — seedha Om ki taraf dekha.

"Kya ye SAHAY hai?"

Om ne haan mein sar hilaya.

Ishaan ki aankhein bhar aayi — ek ajeeb tarah se. "Ye... ye mera sapna tha."

"Sapna tha matlab?" Om ne poochha.

"Matlab," Ishaan ne ek gehri saans li. "Baitho. Batata hoon."

Teeno baith gaye.

Avika ne coffee banayi — teen cups. Avika baithi thi ek taraf, Om doosri taraf, Ishaan beech mein.

"Mere 10th ke boards mein acche marks aaye the," Ishaan ne shuru kiya. "Tab mujhe kaha gaya — ek baar successful ho jao, phir apna passion follow kar lena. SAHAY banana — AI banana — coding — ye mera sapna tha."

Usne cup haath mein ghumaaya. "Aaj successful hoon. Par sapne ke liye time nahi milta. Zindagi aur cheezein le gayi."

Khamoshi.

Om Ishaan ko dekh raha tha. Wahi chehra. Wahi features. Par kitna alag.

Avika ne Om ki taraf dekha. "Mujhe dekh kar itne hairan kyun the?"

Om kuch bolne wala tha — par Ishaan ne haath uthaaya.

"Ruk jao," usne Om se kaha. Seedha. "Past ki baat batana theek hai — par future ki baat jaane se khatra ho sakta hai. Iss universe mein interference nahi chahiye."

Om ne samjha. Sar hilaya.

Par andar kuch tha — ek bhaaripan. Wo Avika ko dekh raha tha — zinda, theek, normal — aur jaanta tha ki kuch nahi keh sakta.

Ishaan SAHAY ke bina bhi bahut kuch hai.

Tabhi SAHAY mein ek warning aayi.

"Om — ek unexpected frequency detect hui hai."

"Kaunsi frequency?"

"Ye frequency maine pehle bhi detect ki thi — France mein. Jab wo alien pod gira tha."

Om seedha ho gaya.

Ishaan ne ye suna. "Alien pod? France mein kya hua?"

"Kuch saal pehle," Om ne kaha. "Par abhi — agar ye wahi frequency hai — toh iska matlab hai ki—"

"Koi aa raha hai," SAHAY ne complete kiya.

Ishaan ne window se bahar dekha. Aasmaan abhi bhi normal tha.

"Ye pehli baar hai," Ishaan ne kaha. "Humare universe mein kuch bhi aisa kabhi nahi hua."

"Mujhe sab batana hoga," Om ne dono ko seedha dekha.

Usne पूरी बात bataayi — INDOVAR, Rakshas, unka planet, unki sena, 7000 saal purani dushmani. Dono ne suna — chup chaap, beech mein nahi toke.

Jab Om khatam hua — Ishaan ne ek pal socha.

"Toh humein rokna hoga. Orbit mein ghusne se pehle."

"Haan," Om ne kaha. "Aur uske liye ek aircraft chahiye. Jisme destroyer laga ho."

Ishaan ne Om ko dekha. Phir SAHAY ko. Phir wapas Om ko.

"Toh banate hain."

Dono ne milke kaam kiya — Ishaan aur Om.

Avika materials laati rahi. SAHAY calculations deta raha. Raat bhar. Din bhar. Phir raat.

Ek aircraft taiyar hua.

Vimaan 2.

Chhota. Tez. Aur usmein ek destroyer laga hua — jo directly alien ship ke core ko target kar sakta tha.

"Main jaaunga," Om ne kaha.

Ishaan ne kuch nahi kaha. Bas ek pal dekha — aur haan mein sar hilaya.

Vimaan 2 ne atmosphere chhoda.

Om akela tha — cockpit mein. SAHAY uske saath.

Alien ship dikhi — vishalkay, kaali, threatening. Orbit mein aa chuki thi — par abhi poori nahi aayi thi.

"SAHAY, target lock karo."

"Locked."

Om ne destroyer ka button haath mein liya. Ek gehri saans.

Tabhi — alien ship se ek beam nikli.

Seedha Vimaan 2 par.

CRASH.

Ship alien craft ke andar ja ghusi — damaged, dhuaan, chingariyan. Om ne belt khole. Bahar nikla.

Andar — andhera tha. Aur aliens the. Hazaron.

Sab ek saath uski taraf aaye.

Om ke paas koi hathiyar nahi tha. Koi Astra Ring nahi.

Bas ek bracelet tha — wahi jo Ishaan ne uski shaadi mein diya tha. Wahi unidentified gem wala.

Aliens kareeb aaye.

Aur phir — bracelet chamka.

Itna tez ki aankhein band ho gayi. Ek energy beam — seedha, wide, poori corridor mein — nikli bracelet se. Jo bhi raste mein tha — gir gaya.

Khamoshi.

Om ne apne haath ko dekha. Bracelet abhi bhi glow kar raha tha — dheere dheere.

"SAHAY... ye kya tha?"

"Baad mein," SAHAY ne kaha. "Pehle ship."

Om aage badha — ek ek karke. Bracelet ne baar baar kaam kiya.

Control room tak pahuncha.

"SAHAY, ship destroy karne ka koi tarika?"

"Ek hi tarika hai," SAHAY ne seedha kaha. "Self destruct sequence. Main activate kar sakta hoon — abhi."

Om ruk gaya.

"Par... main bhi andar hoon."

"Haan," SAHAY ne kaha. Koi sugarcoating nahi. Bas ek fact.

Om ne ek pal socha. Haath kaanpe thode.

Nahi. Koi aur tarika hona chahiye.

"SAHAY, koi aur option?"

"Self destruct ke ilawa — ek hi raasta hai. Timer lagao. Pod mein baitho. Nikal jao."

"Timer lag sakta hai?"

"Minimum 3 minute."

"Toh timer on karo. Main pod se nikal jaaunga."

SAHAY ne sequence activate kiya.

Timer: 3:00. 2:59. 2:58.

Om pod ki taraf bhaga — tez, corridor ke baad corridor. Bracelet halka glow kar raha tha — jaise guide kar raha ho.

Pod room. Darwaza. Pod ke andar jaane wala tha ki —

Alien Commander.

Bada. Bhaari. Uski aankhon mein koi darr nahi tha. Usne Om ko ek haath se pakda — aur pod se door pheka. Om doosri taraf ja gira.

Commander pod mein baitha. Pod ka darwaza band hua. Pod nikal gaya.

Om ne dekha — timer abhi bhi chal raha tha.

0:10. 0:09. 0:08.

Ab kya.

0:03. 0:02. 0:01.

BLAST.

Ship raakh.

Aur Om — space mein. Koi oxygen nahi. Koi ship nahi. Sirf andhera aur tare.

Phir — bracelet.

Ek purple energy field — Om ke charon taraf — ek pal mein ban gayi. Oxygen tha usme. Warmth thi. Jaise ek personal shield — sirf uske liye.

Om space mein float kar raha tha.

Zinda.

Hairan.

"SAHAY," usne dheere se kaha. "Ye bracelet kya hai?"

SAHAY ne ek pal liya.

"Pata nahi Om. Par jo bhi hai — Ishaan jaanta tha ki tujhe zaroorat padegi."



Chapter 3: Tidnap

Space mein float karte hue Om ne dekha —

Pod.

Commander us pod mein tha — aur pod Earth ki taraf badh raha tha. Tez. Seedha.

"SAHAY, pod track karo."

"Tracked. Egypt ki taraf ja raha hai."

Om ne bracelet dekha — abhi bhi glow kar raha tha. Energy field abhi bhi thi..

"SAHAY, kya main is field se directly land kar sakta hoon?"

"Theoretically — haan. Par control tumhare haath mein nahi hoga. Bracelet decide karega."

Om ne ek pal socha. *Koi option nahi.*

"Toh chalte hain."

Pod Egypt mein land hua — ek sunsaan desert mein. Raat ka waqt tha. Charon taraf sirf ret aur door ek ajeeb si roshni.

Kuch second baad — Om bhi land kiya. Seedha ret mein. Ghutne tak dhansa.

Commander pod se bahar aaya. Om ko dekha.

Ek pal ke liye — hairan hua.

Phir muskuraya — wo muskaan jo kabhi achhi nahi hoti.

"Tum yahan tak aaye," usne kaha. Universal Translator on tha — SAHAY ka. "Tumhe dekhkar mujhe hamare purwajon ki ek kahani yaad aati hai — ek aisa praan jo aadha insaan tha, aadha bandar.

"Bahut interesting history hai tumhari," Om ne kaha. "Par abhi tum hamare planet par ho — aur tumhara welcome nahi hua."

Commander ne kuch nahi kaha. Seedha charge kiya — tez, bhaari.

Om ne bas haath aage kiya.

Bracelet.

Ek purple beam — seedha, wide. Commander us beam mein —

Evaporate.

Kuch nahi bacha. Sirf ret tha. Aur khamoshi.

Om ne apne haath ko dekha. Haath kaanp raha tha — darr se nahi, us energy se jo abhi release hui thi.

Om wapas jaane wala tha — Ishaan aur Avika ke paas — ki tabhi uski body mein phir se wo feeling aayi.

Vibration. Glitch.

"Nahi — abhi nahi—"

Par body ne nahi suna.

Andhera.

Jab aankh khuli —

Ek cage tha. High-tech. Transparent walls — par itni mazboot ki haath lagao toh current aata tha. Upar ek light thi — seedhi, tez.

Om ne apne haath dekhe.

Bracelet — nahi tha.

"SAHAY?" Usne dheere se kaha.

Koi response nahi.

SAHAY bhi nahi.

Om ne charon taraf dekha. Cage ke bahar — guards the. Uniform mein. Alag universe — alag uniform.

Thodi der khamoshi mein baitha raha ki tabhi —

Footsteps.

Ek jaana pehchana chehra darwaze par aaya.

Gauri.

Par ye Gauri alag thi — uniform mein, expression tight, aankhon mein koi warmth nahi.

"Tum jaag gaye," usne kaha. Seedha. Official taur par.

"Gauri," Om ne kaha. "Main yahan band kyun hoon? Tum log mere saath kya kar rahe ho?"

Gauri ruk gayi.

"Tum mera naam kaise jaante ho?"

Om ne realize kiya — ye Gauri use nahi jaanti. Ye alag universe tha.

Kuch bolne wala tha ki —

Bahar se ek announcement aayi. Bhaari. Formal.

"Supreme Leader aa rahe hain. Sabhi kneel down karein."

Guards ghutne par baith gaye. Gauri bhi. Cage ke andar Om akela khada tha — confused, bracelet ke bina, SAHAY ke bina.

Darwaza khula.

Ek 7 foot ka aadmi andar aaya. Boodha — par uski presence itni bhaari thi ki kamra chhota lag gaya. Uske kapde ceremonial the — ek aisi civilization ka uniform jo apne aap ko bahut advanced maanti thi.

Baad mein pata chala — uska naam **Kiaririkakato** tha. Par sab use sirf **Tidnap** bulate the.

Usne Om ko dekha. Poora dekha. Upar se neeche.

Phir apne guards ki taraf muda.

"Rakshas hai ye. Abhi maar do isse."

Guards aage badhe.

"Ruko!" Om ne kaha — tez, confident.

Guards ruke. Tidnap ne haath uthaya — guards ko roka.

"Bolo," Tidnap ne kaha.

"Main koi rakshas nahi hoon," Om ne kaha. "Aur lagta hai — tumhare universe mein Ishaan nahi hai. Isliye ye confusion ho rahi hai."

Tidnap ka chehra sakht ho gaya.

"Hamare Bhagwan ka naam apni gandi zubaan se mat lo."

Om aur confuse ho gaya. *Bhagwan? Ishaan yahan Bhagwan hai? kaunsa Ishaan? Aur Gauri mujhe pehchaan nahi rahi. Rakshas ka concept clear nahi. Kuch samajh nahi aa raha.*

Upar se — maarne ka order.

Guards phir aage badhe.

Tabhi — Gauri.

"Tidnap."

Ek awaaz. Par itni confident ki sab ruk gaye.

Tidnap ne Gauri ki taraf dekha. "Kya hai?"

"Aap humse zyada gyaani hain," Gauri ne kaha — seedha, bina dare. "Par mujhe ek baat kehni hai."

Tidnap ne haath se ishaara kiya — bolo.

"Raat ke samay aise rakshason ki taaqat badh jaati hai. Agar abhi isko mara — toh hamare poore pavitra sthal mein negative energy bhar jaayegi. Subah maaro isse — tab ye zyada sahi hoga."

Tidnap ne Gauri ko dekha. Phir Om ko.

Kuch der khamoshi.

"Kal subah," usne kaha. Aur chala gaya.

Raat.

Om cage mein baitha tha — akela. Charon taraf khamoshi. Bahar guards the.

Kal subah kya hoga — ye soochne ki zaroorat nahi thi. Pata tha.

SAHAY nahi. Bracelet nahi. Gauri mujhe nahi pehchaanti. Koi nahi jaanta main kaun hoon.

Ishaan — jo is universe mein apparently Bhagwan hai — wo kahan hai?

Aur phir — footsteps.

Halke. Careful.

Gauri.

Is baar uniform nahi tha — saadharan kapde. Aur haath mein — ek device. Aur ek familiar cheez.

Bracelet.

Usne cage ka lock khola — dheere se, bina awaaz kiye. Andar aayi.

"Chup rehna," usne kaha.

Om ne haan mein sar hilaya.

Usne SAHAY wala device Om ko diya. Phir bracelet.

Om ne bracelet pehna. Ek warmth aayi — familiar.

"Tum mujhe kyun bacha rahi ho?" Om ne dheere se poochha.

Gauri ne ek pal liya. Phir boli — "Hamare yahan ek kitaab hai. Hamare Bhagwan ki — Ishaan ki — likhi hui. Usme sab kuch hai — science, ethics, rules. Hum sab usi ke hisaab se chalte hain."

"Par?"

"Par log uska galat matlab nikal rahe hain. Jo Ishaan ne likha tha — wo ye nahi tha jo Tidnap kar raha hai." Gauri ki awaaz mein ek dard tha — genuine. "Maine wo kitaab hazaaron baar padhi hai. Usme koi 'rakshas maar do' nahi likha."

Om ne suna. Phir SAHAY ko activate kiya.

"SAHAY, status?"

SAHAY ne ek pal liya. "Om — Ishaan ne mujhse ek baar kaha tha. Usne kaha tha ki waqt ke saath log samajhdaar nahi hote — galat direction mein jaate hain. Aur apni burai chhupaane ke liye religion ka istemal karte hain." Pause. "Lagta hai ye universe uska example hai."

Gauri ne ye suna. Uski aankhein bhar aayi — par aansu nahi aaye.

"Tum mera naam kaise jaante ho?" Usne phir poochha — dheere se. Abhi no official tone nahi tha — bas ek sawaal tha.

Om kuch bolne wala tha —

Tabhi uski body mein phir se wo vibration aayi.

Nahi. Phir se nahi. Abhi nahi—

Gauri ne dekha — Om ka chehra badal raha tha.

"Tum theek ho—"

Andhera.



Chapter 4: Home

Jab Om ki aankh khuli —

Ek jaani pehchaani jagah thi.

Usne ek baar dekha. Do baar. Teen baar.

Yahi tha. Wahi gate. Wahi deewar jisme ek jagah paint thodi utri hui thi. Wahi khidki jisme raat ko unka ghar ki roshni bahar aati thi.

Uska ghar.

Om wahan khada raha. Hila nahi. Bol nahi saka.

Aankhein bhar aayi — aur is baar rok nahi paya. Aansu aa gaye — seedhe, bina kisi warning ke. Woh bas dekhta rehna chahta tha. Uss gate ko. Uss deewar ko. Us khidki ko.

Maa andar hogi. Papa andar honge.

Tabhi peeche se ek awaaz aayi —

"Bhai sahab, gate pe mat khade rahiye — thoda side hat jaiye."

Om ne palat ke dekha.

Uski maa thi — saari mein, haath mein sabzi ka thaila — aur unke ek haath mein ek 9 saal ke bacche ka haath tha.

Woh baccha.

Om ne use dekha — aur ek pal ke liye duniya ruk gayi.

Woh baccha aur koi nahi tha. Om hi tha — 9 saal ka. Wohi chehra. Wohi aankhein.

Om side hat gaya — seedha, bina kuch bole. Kyunki jaanta tha — kuch kehna theek nahi hoga. Jo destiny mein likha tha — wahi hoga. Iss moment mein interference nahi karni thi.

Maa ne ek baar Om ko — bade Om ko — dekha. Ek normal nazar. Phir andar chali gayi — chote Om ka haath pakde.

Darwaza band hua.

Bade Om wahan khada raha.

"SAHAY," usne dheere se kaha. Awaaz thodi kaanp rahi thi.

"Haan Om."

"Woh t-shirt — jo chote Om ne pehni thi — mujhe yaad hai. Mere paas bhi thi. 9 saal ki umra mein."

"Haan."

"Matlab ye 2023 hai."

"Haan Om. Tum apne hi past mein ho — ek parallel universe ka past."

Om ne ek lambi saans li. "Matlab Ishaan bhi Delhi aa gaya hoga. Abhi. Iss waqt."

"Logically — haan."

"Aur uska dimaag..." Om ne ruka. "9 saal ki umra mein jo main soch raha tha — uski koi comparison nahi thi mere aaj ke dimaag se. Ishaan toh..."

"Ishaan ka dimaag tumhare aaj ke dimaag se bhi aage hoga," SAHAY ne complete kiya.

Om ne ek baar apne ghar ki taraf dekha — darwaza band tha, par roshni thi andar.

"Address batao Ishaan ka."

Us gali mein ek building thi — seedhi, normal.

Om ne door ka bell dabaya.

Darwaza khula — Bhuvan.

Chota Bhuvan. College wala. Abhi ISRO nahi — abhi bas ek ladka tha.

"Aap kaun?"

"Lambi kahani hai," Om ne kaha. "Andar aa ke bataaun?"

Bhuvan ne ek pal socha. Phir rasta diya.

Ghar mein bas Bhuvan tha.

Om ne sab bataya — Universe Teleporter, glitches, alag alag universes, Tidnap, Egypt. Poora. Bhuvan ne suna — beech mein nahi toka — sirf sunta raha.

Jab Om khatam hua — Bhuvan ne ek pal liya.

"Ishaan kahan hai?" Om ne poochha.

Bhuvan ka chehra badal gaya.

"Wo... hospital gaya hai. Mummy Papa ke saath."

"Kyun?"

Bhuvan ne ek lambi saans li. "Kuch din pehle — shaam ko wo ground par gaya tha. Akela. \ Par jab bahut der tak wapas nahi aaya toh hum dekhne gaye."

Ruka.

"Wahan tha — par... theek nahi tha. Uske poore sharir mein kuch tha — red electric sa — jo hamesha chalta rehta tha. Aankhein khuli thi par dekh nahi raha tha. Bolne ki koshish karta tha par words nahi nikalte the."

Om ka dimaag tez chala. *Red electric. Har waqt. Koi doctor nahi pehchaan paa raha.*

"Kitne din se?" Om ne poochha.

"Teen din."

Bell baji.

Bhuvan gate ki taraf gaya.

Om wahan baitha raha — soch raha tha. *Red electric current. Ye normal condition nahi hai. Ye kuch aur hai. Kuch jo is universe mein pehle kabhi nahi hua hoga.*

Bahar se awaazein aayi — Bhuvan kuch bata raha tha kisi ko. Phir — footsteps. Tez.

Om uthne wala tha ki —

Ek chota sa ladka — 9 saal ka — seedha Om ke paas aaya. Aur ek jhatke mein —

Bracelet cheen liya.

Om ke haath se.

"Ruko—" Om uske peeche bhaga. "Woh chodo—"

Par ladka ruk gaya tha — bracelet haath mein — aur uski aankhon mein ek ajeeb si roshni thi. Red. Electric.

Ishaan.

9 saal ka Ishaan — jo teen din se "theek nahi" tha — uski aankhon mein wahi red current tha. Par ab bracelet haath mein tha — aur wo seedha Om ko dekh raha tha.

Jaise pehchaanta ho.

Jaise jaanta ho.

"Woh chodo please—" Om ne haath aage badhaya.

Aur tabhi —

Uski body mein woh vibration.

Glitch.

Nahi — abhi nahi — Ishaan ke paas bracelet hai — SAHAY—

Andhera.



Chapter 5: Demons Universe

Andhera.

andhera.

Om ki aankh khuli — par fark nahi pada. Charon taraf sirf kaala tha. Koi roshni nahi. Koi awaaz nahi.

Kahan hoon?

Tabhi — ek halki si siskari. Door se. Phir doosri.

.Usne haath uthaya — bracelet dhundha. Par wahan kuch nahi tha. Sirf uski khali kalai.

Bracelet nahi hai. Ishaan ke paas hai.

Pehle ek second tak toh normal raha — phir yaad aaya. Bracelet nahi matlab — koi shield nahi. Koi beam nahi. Koi protection nahi.

Andheron mein se aakritiyan ubhri. Ek. Phir teen. Phir bhot.

Demons.

Sab ek direction mein badh rahe the — seedha Om ki taraf.

Om ne peeche hatne ki koshish ki — par kuch nahi tha peeche. Sirf andhera.

Yahan khatam hoga sab.

Aur tabhi —

BLAST.

Itna bada ki poora demon universe ek pal ke liye roshni mein dub gaya. Sab demons — jo Omki taraf aa rahe the — ek pal mein khatam.

Khamoshi.

Om ne palat ke dekha.

Ek insaan khada tha — haath mein ek ajeeb sa weapon. Kapde phate hue. Aankhon mein thakaan — par aankhon mein ek determination bhi jo familiar lagti thi.

Chehra — Om ka apna chehra.

Par alag. Zyada thaka hua. Zyada purana.

Om .

"Jaldi yahan aao," Om ne kaha. "Aur baad mein explain karna ki tum yahan kaise aaye."

Ek tooti hui lab. Wahi purani roshni. Wahi khamoshi.



Om 1 ne sab bataya — poora. Universal Teleporter, glitches, Egypt, Tidnap, Ishaan ka ghar, bracelet.

Om 2 ne suna — chup chaap.

Jab Om 1 khatam hua — Om 1 ne ek thaki hui saans li aur bola:

"Pichle 24 ghanton mein ye teesri se chauthi baar sunna raha hoon ye kahani. "

Om 2 seedha uthke ek drawer ke paas gaya. Usme se ek chhota sa device nikala — flat, circular.

"Haath aage karo."

"Ye kya hai?"

"Haath aage karo pehle."

Om 1 ne haath aage kiya. Om 2 ne device uski kalai par laga diya — click ki awaaz. Tight ho gaya.

"Ab tum kisi aur universe mein nahi jaoge," Om 2 ne kaha. "Ye device tumhare body ke glitch pattern ko lock kar deta hai."

"Tumhe is device ke baare mein kaise pata?" Om 1 ne poochha.

Om 2 ne ek pal liya. "Kuch saal pehle — tumhare universe ke Ishaan yahan aaye the. Wo iss device ko pehli baar bana rahe the — par itne achhe se jaante kaise the? Kyunki ye design unhone bahut pehle bana liya tha. Jab yahan the — tab bhi. Usne mere saath baat ki thi iss problem ke baare mein. Solution bhi bataya tha."

"Toh mujhe kya karna hoga?"

"Jo device maine lagaya hai — usse lagaake tumhe kam se kam 1 se 2 mahine deep freeze mein rehna padega. Tabhi ye properly kaam karega."

Om 1 ne device ko dekha.

Tabhi — SAHAY ki awaaz aayi.

"Uss waqt main bhi tha Ishaan ke saath — mujhe ye kyun nahi pata?"

Om 2 ne SAHAY ki taraf dekha. "Bahut si cheezein hain jo tumhe nahi pata. Uss waqt Ishaan ne tumhe Waqt-Bandh ke creation par focus karne bola tha. Tum focus mode mein doosri cheezein notice nahi karte."

"Arre haan," SAHAY ne kaha — thodi sharmindagi ke saath.

"Par," Om 2 ne kaha, "abhi jo tumne bataya — us pichle universe mein Ishaan ki aankhon mein red current — ye mujhe kuch yaad dila raha hai."

SAHAY ne kaha — "us pichle universe mein Ishaan ki aankhon mein red current — ye mujhe kuch yaad dila raha hai. Jab Dimensional Nexus mein Ishaan aur Manvik lad rahe the — usse pehle Manvik ne kaha tha ki wo ek aisa universe mein gira tha — jahan usne chote Ishaan ki knowledge absorb kar li thi."

Dono Om — ek saath — ekdum still ho gaye.

Om 2 ne dheere se kaha — "Matlab wo red current..."

"Manvik tha," Om 1 ne complete kiya. "Ya Manvik ka asar tha. Chote Ishaan ke andar."

Khamoshi.

Itni bhaari ki demon universe ki dhund bhi halki lagti.

Om 2 ne ek aur device nikala — Waqt-Bandh.

Om 1 ke haath mein rakha.

"Apne universe mein jao. Aur seedha deep freeze mein chale jao. 1 se 2 mahine. Bich mein bahar mat nikalna□"

"Aur us universe mein jo ho raha hai—"

"Jo hona hai — hoga," Om 2 ne kaha. Uski awaaz mein koi drama nahi tha — sirf ek thandak thi jo tab aati hai jab koi bahut kuch dekh chuka ho.

Om 1 ne ek baar Om 2 ko dekha.

Wahi chehra. Wahi aankhein. Par kitna alag.

Kya main bhi aisa ho jaaunga?

Usne Waqt-Bandh activate kiya.

Lab.

Apni. Jaani pehchaani.

Bhuvan, Mikhail, Gauri, Kenji — charon screens par kuch dekh rahe the, kuch baat kar rahe the — tabhi Om ko dekha aur sab ek saath uski taraf daude.

"Om! Kahan tha tu? 3 din se—"

"Teen din?" Om ne hairan hokar kaha.

"Haan teen din! Gauri ne bataya ki tu achanak gayab ho gaya — hum dhundh rahe the—"

"Baad mein batata hoon sab," Om ne kaha. "Abhi ek kaam hai."

Usne unhe poori kahani bataayi — condensed version. Glitches. Universes. Om 2. Device. Deep freeze.

Jab khatam hua — Kenji ne seedha poochha:

"Kitne time ke liye?"

"1 se 2 mahine."

Bhuvan ne ek pal Om ko dekha. Phir haan mein sar hilaya.

Gauri kuch bolne wali thi — par Om ne pehle hi kaha:

"Main theek hoon. Aur wapas aaunga. Par abhi ye zaruri hai."

Lab ke ek kone mein ek special chamber tha — IKS ki technology ka hissa. Deep freeze ke liye banaya hua — medical emergencies ke liye.

Om usme baitha.

Bhuvan ne controls check kiye. Mikhail ne temperature set ki. Kenji ne ek baar Om ko dekha — aur sirf itna bola:

"Wapas aa jaana."

Om ne muskuraya.

Chamber ka darwaza band hua. Thandi hawa aane lagi — dheere dheere. Om ki aankhein bhaari hone lagi.

Aakhri cheez jo usne sochi —

Chote Ishaan ki aankhon mein red current. Manvik ka asar. Bracelet ab Ishaan ke paas hai.

1 se 2 mahine. Phir dekhenge.

Aankhein band ho gayi.

